

Warm-up writing practice

- _____ 'whole'
- _____ 'half, in the middle'
- _____ 'four people'; 'you say'
- _____ 'pot, bucket'
- _____ 'too, overly'
- _____ 'frog'
- _____ 'it's fresh'
- _____ 'person, man'; 'bull moose'
- _____ 'reserve, village'
- _____ 'fear'
- _____ 'they'

Review of vowels

A good way to review vowel sounds and spellings is to observe the following pairs of related words. In each pair, the final syllable of the word contains a different vowel. In some of these words the following consonant is also different.

a ~ i

c'i'alh	'she's eating'
c'ita'ilh	'she's going to eat'
dinī de'as	'a group of people is going into a feast'
dinī deta'is	'a group will go into a feast, there will be a feast'

ī ~ i

k'inīnyīs	'break it (in two)'
k'itanyīs	'you're going to break it (in two)'
didīwhdīlh	'get up, stand up (you pl.)'
diditawhdīlh	'you pl. will get up, stand up'

i ~ e

stl'it	'my fart, my low back'
sitl'et	'he farted'
ntendzelh	'throw it (ball)'
yintēzdzil	'he threw it (ball)'
bilh holtset (tsit)	'chase him off'
bilh holtsit	'you chased him off'
'ats hontset (tsit)	'throw them out'
'ats hoyintsit	'he threw them out'

ē ~ e

we'aadit'ēn'	'they started'
we'aaditat'elh	'they're going to start'

o ~ i

ičlhcot

‘I took it, I’m taking it’

taclhcilh

‘I’m going to take it’

u ~ i

haditgut

‘it (vapor) is flowing up, out’

haditgit

‘it (vapor) flowed up, out’

nebesizut

‘he skated in a circle’

nebetazilh

‘he’s going to skate in a circle’

ë ~ i

tikës

‘a vehicle (car, bus) is leaving’

takwis

‘a vehicle (car, bus) is going to leave’

neniwhhtës

‘lie down (you pl.)

nets’intatis

‘we’re going to lie down’

e ~ a

halho’ nenagh

‘the cloth fell down’

halho’ nenekh

‘the cloth is falling’

a ~ ë

hitsagh

‘she’s crying’

ïntsëgh

‘she (or you sg.) cried’

Vowel writing practice

1. _____ 'It started to flood.'
2. _____ 'It will flood, it's going to flood.'
3. _____ 'It's rolling away.'
4. _____ 'It's going to roll away.'
5. _____ 'Snap it off.'
6. _____ 'You're going to snap it off.'
7. _____ 'He ripped it once, started to rip it.'
8. _____ 'Rip it, start ripping it.'
9. _____ 'Pick them up (beads).'
10. _____ 'You're going to pick them up (beads).'
11. _____ 'Kick it to pieces.'
12. _____ 'I'm going to kick it to pieces.'

Possessive prefixes

In Witsuwit'en, like other Dene languages, the possessor of a noun, if pronominal, is indicated with a prefix to the noun. Compare the following:

sbep ~ sibep	'my father'
bibep	'his/her father'
niwhbep	'our, your (pl.) father'
hibibep	'their father'
mbep ~ nyibep	'your father'

We can describe the list above as the noun **-bep** 'father' being inflected for possessor (via the addition of a possessive prefix). The possessor and the noun itself are a single word in Witsuwit'en whereas they are translated with two words into English.

Note that even if there is a nominal (noun) possessor, the possessive prefix is commonly used, especially with a human possessor. Thus:

Birdie bibep	'Birdie's father' (lit. 'Birdie her-father')
'enī hibibep	'those people's father' (lit. 'they their-father')

Two of these *possessive prefixes* have variant forms, a long and a short form. These are **s-** ~ **si-** 'my' and **nyi-** ~ **n/m-** 'your (sg.)'. We will see below that when the short forms of 'your (sg.)' are used, **m-** is used before **b** and **n-** is used elsewhere. It is never wrong to use the long forms of 'me' and 'your (sg.)', but the short forms are very commonly heard except as noted below (some rules will be given).

When the possessed noun begins with **s** or **z**, the long form of 'my' must be used (and the long form of 'your' is generally preferred):

sunye	'money'
sisunye, sisunye'	'my money'
nyisunye, nyisunye'	'your money'
bisunye, bisunye'	'his/her money'
hibisunye, hibisunye'	'their money'
niwhsunye, niwhsunye'	'our, your (pl.) money'

When a noun begins with **'**, the long forms are preferred as well:

'usa	'pot, bucket'
si'usa'	'my pot, bucket'
nyi'usa'	'your pot, bucket'
bi'usa'	'his/her pot, bucket'
hibi'usa'	'their pot, bucket'
niwh'usa'	'our, your (pl.) pot, bucket'

When a noun begins with **m**, the long form of 'your (sg.)' must be used:

smīs ~ simīs	'my cheek'
nyimīs	'your cheek'
bimīs	'his/her cheek'
hibimīs	'their cheek'
niwhmīs	'our, your (pl.) cheek'

Notice that the basic form of 'money', **sunye**, and the basic form of 'pot, bucket', **'usa**, change slightly when possessed. These are called *possessed forms* of nouns. The possessed form is usually listed with a hyphen in front of it, to signify that a prefix must be added. Many nouns have slight differences between the possessed and the basic forms. Here are some more examples. There is not always agreement between speakers on what the possessed form should be so you need to be able to accurately write what you hear.

lhic, -lic 'dog'

bilic 'his/her dog'

hibilic 'their dog'

slic ~ silic 'my dog'

nlic ~ nyilic 'your dog'

niwhlic 'our, your (pl.) dog'

khēlh, -ghīl 'pack' (or kēlh, for some speakers)

sghīl ~ sighīl 'my pack'

bighīl 'his/her pack'

hibighīl 'their pack'

nghīl ~ nyighīl 'your pack'

niwhghīl 'our, your (pl.) pack'

When the possessed form begins with a vowel, as in the following example, the long form of 'your (sg.)' must always be used. And the vowel **i** that normally occurs with the other postpositional prefixes drops out:

skiy', -izkiy' 'blood'

sizkiy' 'my blood'

nyizkiy' 'your blood'

bizkiy' 'his/her blood'

niwhizkiy' 'our (your pl.) blood'

hibizkiy' 'their blood'

Here are some more basic and possessed forms of noun:

basic

possessed

skak 'child, children'

bizkak 'his/her children'

dzekh 'pitch'

bidzek 'its pitch'

hinic 'language'

bikinic 'his/her language'

khiz 'pus'

bighiz 'its pus'

Writing practice

For the following nouns, figure out and write the five possessed forms of each noun (the entire word: prefix + possessed noun). If you think both long and short forms of 'my' and 'your (sg.)' should be possible, write both forms.

ka 'car', -ka' (possessed form)

'my car' _____

'your car' _____

'his/her car' _____

'their car' _____

'our, your (pl.) car' _____

lhok 'fish', -lok (possessed form)

'my fish' _____

'your fish' _____

'his/her fish' _____

'their fish' _____

'our, your (pl.) fish' _____

tselh 'axe', possessed -tsel

'my axe' _____

'your axe' _____

'his/her axe' _____

'their axe' _____

'our, your (pl.) axe' _____

tl'olh 'rope', possessed -tl'ol

'my rope' _____

'your rope' _____

'his/her rope' _____

'their rope' _____

'our, your (pl.) rope' _____